SPARK OF LIFE®
LIVING FORWARD

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A FREE GUIDE FROM SPARK OF LIFE

Why Grief Comes *in Waves*

Gentle answers to the questions you're asking, and what to do when a wave rolls in

Since 2009 • Over 150 retreats • Over 100 church workshops • 10,000+ people helped

Welcome. You're in the right place.

If you're reading this, you may be carrying something heavy. Maybe your loss is new. Maybe it's been years, and a song on the radio can still stop you in your tracks.

Either way, you're asking good questions. "Why does grief come in waves?" is one of the questions people ask Google most about grief.[1] You are far from alone.

This short guide gives you gentle answers, plus a few simple tools for the days when a wave rolls in. Read it all at once, or one page at a time. There's no wrong way.

Since 2009, Spark of Life has walked beside more than 10,000 grieving people. Here's what we've learned along the way: life can never be the same after loss, and it can still be rich and full.

We're so glad you're here.

Your friends at Spark of Life

Why grief comes in waves

Grief doesn't move in a straight line. It moves more like the sea.

Some days the water is calm. You laugh, you work, you make plans. Then something small brings a wave rolling in, all at once.

What can bring a wave

- A song you both loved
- A smell, like their coffee or their cologne
- A photo, a voice message or their handwriting
- A favorite restaurant, a street or a familiar place
- Birthdays, anniversaries and holidays
- A change of seasons
- Hearing their name, or a joke only the two of you shared

Holidays, birthdays and other days can stir up grief even years after a loss.[2] That's normal.

A wave is not a step backward

When a wave hits, it can feel like you're starting over. You're not. A wave is a sign of how much they mean to you.[3]

Waves come, and waves go. As you learn to carry your loss, many people find the calm between the waves grows longer. The love stays. The grief changes shape.

The questions you're asking

These are some of the questions people ask most about grief.[1] Here are our gentle answers.

How long does grief last?

There's no deadline. Grief doesn't end. It changes shape. You don't have to get over your loss. You can learn to carry it in a healthier way, and live forward with it.

Is it normal to feel this way?

Almost certainly, yes. Grief can touch your heart, your sleep, your focus, your body and even your faith. It's OK to not be OK. Giving yourself permission to grieve is a brave first step.

Why is grief so lonely?

No one else lost exactly what you lost. And the world often moves on before you're ready. The loneliness starts to ease when you're with people who understand.

How do I stop grieving?

You don't have to stop loving them. The goal isn't to stop grieving. It's to grieve in a way that lets you live again.

Will I ever feel joy again?

Yes. Joy often comes back quietly at first: a good morning, a real laugh, a moment of peace. Feeling joy doesn't mean you've forgotten them. It means their love is still at work in you.

Why do I feel stuck?

Feeling stuck doesn't mean you're doing grief wrong. Often a few "boulders" sit in the way, like regrets, unanswered questions or words never said. Boulders can be moved.

When a wave rolls in: seven small steps

Keep this page somewhere you'll see it. On a hard day, you only need one of these.

1. **Name it.** Say to yourself, "This is a wave. It will pass." Waves always do.[3]
2. **Breathe slowly.** Take a few slow, deep breaths. Let your body settle.[4]
3. **Let it come.** Tears are not weakness. You don't have to fight the wave to get through it.
4. **Find a quiet spot.** Step outside, sit in your car, or find a quiet room for a few minutes.[4]
5. **Reach out to one person.** Call or text someone who will listen without trying to fix it.
6. **Say their name.** Talk about them, write to them, or look at a favorite photo.
7. **Take one small step.** Drink a glass of water. Take a short walk. One small thing is enough for today.

Make a little comfort kit

Gather a few things that help you on hard days: a favorite photo, a card with a verse or kind words, a journal, a playlist. Keep it close, so it's ready when a wave comes.[4]

Your wave plan

Some waves you can see coming. A little planning ahead can turn a hard day into a gentler one.[2] Take a few quiet minutes with this page.

Days that may be hard this year

Places, songs or things that may bring a wave

People I can call or text

Things that comfort me

One way I'd like to honor them

One kind thing I'll do for myself this week

You don’t have to ride the waves alone

Waves are part of loving someone. Living forward is learning to ride them, and to find meaning, hope and even joy again. Here are three ways we’d be honored to walk beside you.

The Living Forward Course

Heal at your own pace, at home. Twelve video lessons with David Mathews, a 60-page workbook and lifetime access. Each lesson ends with one simple step. Lessons include:

- Hope Is Still Here: Your First Step Out of the Dark
- It’s OK to Not Be OK: Giving Yourself Permission to Grieve
- Why Am I Still Stuck? Removing the Boulders That Hold You Back
- From Anchors to Sails: Discovering Meaning and Living Forward

Start The Living Forward Course sparkoflife.org/courses

A grief retreat

Three and a half days with a small group of people who understand, in person or online. **sparkoflife.org/retreats →**

One-on-one coaching

A certified grief coach who has walked this road too. **sparkoflife.org/coaching →**

Not sure where to start? Call or text us at 1-844-LIVE-FWD (1-844-548-3393). We’d love to hear from you.

A gentle note

If your grief feels like more than you can carry today, you can call or text 988 any time.

This guide is not a substitute for professional care, and it works well alongside it.

About Spark of Life

David and Debbie Mathews started Spark of Life in 2009 out of their personal losses. Since then, they've led over 150 retreats and over 100 church workshops, and walked beside more than 10,000 grieving people from 46 states and around the world.

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SOURCES

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0. Mayo Clinic Health System, "7 Steps for Managing Grief and Loss."
0. The Loss Foundation, "Understanding Triggers in Grief."
0. GriefShare, "How to Handle Grief Ambushes."